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Libyan politics

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What is the historical status of this image?

The image is an artefact, one made by an outsider. Zuwaya made it from elements which they knew, enjoyed, celebrated: they recited their genealogies and explained them, they told their stories, made jokes, listened to poems on cassette-recorders. But they did not maintain an image; or at least, not until an outsider pressed them, assembled one from what he thought were the parts, tried it out on them and modified it to accommodate their comments and additional information. As nearly as one person can be sure of 18,000 others, the image gained their assent. They accepted it as a general statement of how things were in the past.

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The absence of an internal hierarchy culminating in a sovereign was the most important element in the image as people saw it; and it was an accurate account of Zuwaya political organization until they invited the Sanusis to Kufra. In other respects, the image is implausible, demands qualification. Yet men did die; they did resist Turks and Italians by battle and by evasion; they did collect taxes from passers-by, and almost certainly distributed the proceeds to household heads. They made peaces, and created a fragmented Peace (fragile and ungoverned) from a series of bilateral contracts between groups as well as by reciprocal threats. The image is not wholly false; but nor is it wholly true. Perhaps it represents [206](#) not a past concrete social reality as it actually existed, but rather the ideas men who lived then had about their responsibilities and claims, their liabilities and privileges and freedom. This is an utterly tentative suggestion; but the question 'To what is the image true?' clearly deserves some sort of answer.

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